Hands-On AI: Automate Data Analytics and Reporting with n8n

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The Anatomy of a Good Prompt

There are four essential components to master to turn basic AI requests into powerful, reliable workflows.

1. Goal
2. Output format
3. Requirements
4. Context and Data

Structure your prompts like a newspaper article: most important information first, largest data volume at the bottom. This hierarchy helps the AI prioritize and pattern-match effectively.

1. Goal	**The Foundation:** Clearly define the core objective for the AI. **Example:** "Write an email that summarizes these ad campaigns. These are all low-performing CTR campaigns."
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2. Output Format	**The Structure:** Instruct the AI on the desired presentation. **Example:** "Return the response as a JSON object with a specific structure including a header (to, subject, from) and a body containing HTML-formatted email content."
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3. Requirements	**The Constraints:** Set boundaries for style, tone, and content. **Example:** "Format as HTML using specific tags (<p>, <h2>, etc.); address recipient as "Hi, Account Manager"; sign off with "Best regards, Dawn"; include professional summary, key metrics, and actionable recommendations; state auto-generation disclaimer; use HTML tables for data."
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4. Campaign Data	**The Context:** Provide necessary background information. **Example:** "Insert the full campaign data here as a stringified JSON object: {{ JSON.stringify($input.all(), null, 2) }}

AI is a pattern-matching engine. When you provide clear structure like a main goal, output format, constraints, and additional context, then you're programming behavior through language. The more intentional your hierarchy, the more reliable your results.